

FOOD SERVICE MANAGEMENT

This regulation supports School Board Policy 6150 (Food Service Management) by establishing nutrient standards that guide the menu planning process. It ensures compliance and outlines procurement practices and documentation requirements for all products served in Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) under the United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) Child Nutrition Programs (CNP).

A. Definitions.

1. United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) Child Nutrition Programs (CNP). The USDA is a federal agency that manages programs and policies related to agriculture, food, natural resources, and rural development, and directs the following CNPs: National School Lunch Program (NSLP); School Breakfast Program (SBP); Child and Adult Care Food Program (CACFP); and Summer Food Service Program (SFSP).

2. Dietary Guidelines for Americans (DGAs). Revised every five years by the USDA and the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS), the DGAs offer evidence-based recommendations for food and beverage choices. These guidelines help individuals meet their nutritional needs, enhance overall health, and reduce the risk of chronic diseases.

3. Richard B. Russell National School Lunch Act. Richard B. Russell National School Lunch Act is a 1946 federal law that created the NSLP to provide low-cost or free school lunch meals to qualified students through subsidies to schools.

4. Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act of 2010 (HHFKA). The HHFKA is a federal law that reauthorized funding for child nutrition and free lunch programs in schools. This legislation has significantly improved the quality of school meals by increasing the availability of whole grains and fruits while placing limits on refined grains and empty calories.

5. Product Formulation Statement (PFS). A Product Formulation Statement (PFS) is a document developed by manufacturers that provides detailed ingredient information demonstrating how the product contributes to the meal pattern and ensures compliance with nutritional standards.

6. Buy American Provision. The Buy American Provision mandates that all

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CNP operators in the continental United States exclusively purchase domestic agricultural commodities and food products. This requirement not only protects the health and well-being of our nation's children but also bolsters the United States economy by supporting American farmers and small, local agricultural businesses.

7. Geographic Preference. A geographic preference allows CNP operators to prioritize purchasing food products grown or raised locally within a designated area. This preference provides an advantage to vendors offering these items during contract bidding, enabling operators to source food closer to home and thereby support local farmers and strengthen regional economies.

B. LCPS General Guidelines. The goal of the Division of School Nutrition Services (SNS) is to ensure that LCPS students are well-nourished and fully able to engage in all educational opportunities available to them. School menus will be planned to align with the current DGAs, as mandated by the USDA per the Richard B. Russell National School Lunch Act. This ensures that meals are age-appropriate for specific grade groups while adhering to dietary specifications for calories, sodium, and saturated fat, thereby reducing the risk of chronic diseases, and in accordance with the following menu planning guidelines:

1. School menus will be designed to include ample amounts of fresh fruits, vegetables, whole grains, meat/meat alternates, and milk, promoting healthy eating patterns that support nutrient adequacy.

2. In compliance with USDA regulations for the NSLP, SNS will make necessary menu modifications to accommodate students with disabilities who have dietary restrictions.

3. The gradual reduction of added sugars and sodium, as recommended in the Dietary Guidelines for Americans (DGAs) and outlined in the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act (HHFKA), along with the elimination of specific color additives, will influence current and future menu selections.

4. Menus will feature a diverse array of foods, allowing students to choose from multiple entrees and side dishes. This variety will expose students to numerous options, ensuring they experience a wide range of cultural foods, flavors, and nutrients throughout the month.

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5. A variety of low-fat milk options, including both low-fat and skim, will be made available daily as part of the menu offering.

6. CACFP afterschool snack and supper menus will include a balanced selection of milk, grains, fruits, vegetables, and meat/meat alternates.

7. All a la carte items sold shall meet the standard for the USDA's Smart Snacks requirements.

C. CNP Procurement.

CNP regulations influence both the procurement of products and the necessary documentation for federal reimbursement.

1. Key restrictions on ingredients include limits on sodium, added sugars, saturated and trans fats, and calories, with a requirement that at least 80% of the grains offered weekly must be whole grain rich. Consequently, contract language outlines permissible levels of these ingredients in food and beverages, and vendors must provide Product Formulation Statements (PFS) to demonstrate compliance.

2. The Buy American Provision requires all CNP operators in the continental United States to exclusively purchase domestic agricultural commodities and food products and LCPS contract language shall outline this requirement. If non-domestic products are purchased with program funds, operators must retain documentation explaining the reasons for these purchases to ensure compliance with this provision.

3. While not mandatory, CNP operators are encouraged to procure local foods for school meals. LCPS SNS contracts define "local" as products sourced from within a 250-mile radius of the LCPS Administration Building in Ashburn, VA. Although local procurement is optional, the Virginia Department of Education's School and Community Nutrition Office tracks the sourcing locations and total dollar amounts spent on local products annually.

Adopted: 03/14/25

Legal Refs.: Code of Virginia, 1950, as amended, §§ 22.1-70, 22.1-78, 22.1-89.1, 22.1-115, 42 U.S.C. § 1751 et seq. § 22.1-207.4:3.

Cross Refs: Policy 6150, Food Service Management